

things, but try to identify things that play on your mind, things that you often find yourself dwelling on. Then, expand the picture out. Look at where you were in your life, what you knew and didn't know. How you were feeling, how much you were earning – everything. Remember that this past version of you didn't have a crystal ball, and had no way of knowing what was lurking around the corner. You can do this in your head, of course, but you might find it a bit easier and more memorable if you do it on paper – it'll also help you a little later on.

Viewing your money mistakes in context is the first step towards forgiving yourself and moving on, which is a vital element of financial wellbeing. It will also help you to see past the shame and embarrassment to the *lesson*, that kernel of goodness right at the centre of the mistake or failure.

Challenge yourself to think about things differently

As you start to add context and explore the circumstances under which you made your mistakes, you might find yourself starting to consider things differently. That shame and self-loathing that you might have been feeling, the wince-inducing heat of the things you did wrong, might begin to fade as you start to become aware of your reasons for tripping up. The gut reaction for many people here, myself included, is to experience